

A CLOCKWORK ORANGE

Stanley Kubrick, 1971

Adapted from Anthony Burgess's dystopian novella, *A Clockwork Orange* is an anarchic and inventive satire that aroused so much controversy over its violent content that Kubrick himself withdrew it from release in the UK for 30 years. In futuristic London, sociopathic delinquent Alex (Malcolm McDowell) and his gang of "droogs" go on a spree of "ultraviolence" that ends in rape and murder. Alex is later arrested, and the institutional violence to which he is in turn subjected robs him of his humanity. **See also:** *Dr. Strangelove* 176–79 ■ *2001: A Space Odyssey* 192–93

HAROLD AND MAUDE

Hal Ashby, 1971

Hal Ashby's dark comedy *Harold and Maude* breaks many taboos in its story of an unlikely relationship between a young man and a 79-year-old woman. They meet through their mutual interest in funerals, but their characters could not be more different. Harold (Bud Cort) is morbid and suicide obsessed, doing his best to thwart his mother's efforts to make him conform to the expectations of his privileged upbringing. Maude (Ruth Gordon) relishes every moment of life, with a complete disregard for rules and disdain for money. The movie's ending reveals a secret that explains Maude's attitude. In the background looms the threat of Vietnam for Harold, as his uncle tries to persuade him to enlist. It is a warm, irreverent movie with moments of comic genius.

LAND OF SILENCE AND DARKNESS

Werner Herzog, 1971

Werner Herzog's documentary follows a deaf-blind German woman who works on behalf of other deaf-blind people. The movie depicts the isolation of severely disabled people who are largely excluded from modern life. The woman, Fini, has lost her sight and hearing in her youth, but many of those she visits have been born deaf-blind, and struggle to connect with others in any way. Their obvious distress is harrowing, but Herzog also tries to convey the possibilities of a rich inner life for someone whose contact with the world is through taste, smell, and touch. Since the 1970s, Herzog has made a number of documentaries that attempt to capture a poetic truth about their subjects' everyday lives.

See also: *Aguirre, the Wrath of God* 206–07

WALKABOUT

Nicolas Roeg, 1971

Based on James Vance Marshall's novel, Nicolas Roeg's beautiful and haunting movie *Walkabout* is about a teenage schoolgirl (Jenny Agutter) and her young brother (Luc Roeg) stranded in the Australian outback after their father kills himself. They meet an Aboriginal boy (David Gulpilil) who helps them survive in the wild, though communication between them is difficult. Metaphors abound in Roeg's movie, and the outback has a hallucinogenic intensity, full of movement and color, suggesting a vibrancy and an

unpredictability in the desert that is absent from the ordered world of the city.

See also: *Don't Look Now* 210–13

THE HARDER THEY COME

Perry Henzell, 1972

Perry Henzell's *The Harder They Come* is the movie credited with popularizing reggae music beyond its Jamaican home, with a sound track by Desmond Dekker and The Maytals, and a title track by Jimmy Cliff, who also plays the movie's lead, Ivanhoe "Ivan" Martin. Country boy Ivan comes to Kingston, Jamaica, full of hope, but when every avenue leads to nothing, including the song he wrote and recorded, he turns to drug dealing, and becomes a trigger-happy gangster. Despite the movie's grim ending, it has an energy that matches its sound track.

A WOMAN UNDER THE INFLUENCE

John Cassavetes, 1974

A Woman Under the Influence was a family affair, with the director's wife Gena Rowlands taking the lead, and with both of the couple's mothers in the movie, too. Rowlands plays Mabel, who is so unstable in her desperation to please that her husband Nick (Peter Falk) commits her to an institution. However, Nick proves no better than Mabel at looking after their children. Upon her release Mabel seems unable to cope, but the children's profession of love for her seems to offer hope. Cassavetes' picture of the family is unflinching but ultimately liberating in its freedom from judgement.